Inside Al

By David S. Baker

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Actor 1: Al and Beth
Actor 2: Inside Al and Jason

AL: *He is the outside Al, the body. He is a 39-year old victim of cerebral palsy. His speech is slow and sometimes hard to understand, especially when he is upset or excited.*

INSIDE AL: *He is Al's mind and feelings. He is perceptive, blunt and sometimes bitter. His speech is extremely articulate and fluid.*

JASON: *Average 16-year old boy*

BETH: *Insecure, frightened child of 16 who hides her fear by using and abusing those she comes in contact with. She manipulates all of her relationships and takes advantage of anyone who is weak-willed enough to let her.*

(Al walks stiffly onstage. Inside Al is behind and slightly to one side of him moving with him in perfect synchronization. Al and Inside Al speak sometimes together and sometimes alternatively, but the feel is that the words are coming from the same person, even if from different mouths – the feel is still that of a monologue)

NOTE: *Inside Al should assume the body position of AL before he speaks each line and then "morph" out of the crippled body into the character of Al's mind and feelings*

AL/INSIDE AL: *(Simultaneously)* Hi. I'm Al. Alvin Theodore Willson *(They chuckle)*

INSIDE AL: . . . Always makes me think of the Chipmunks.

AL: People stay away from me, mostly. I have cerebral palsy.

INSIDE AL: Sometimes, though, I feel like I have leprosy or something. They stare at me or say I'm dumb – retarded. I'm not, though.

AL: My mind tells my body to do things, and my body doesn't cooperate very well . . . but I'm not dumb.

AL/INSIDE AL: They don't know me.

INSIDE AL: When I walk to the market, people smile and wave at me as they go by. I know that as soon as they pass, they quit smiling. They stop and think.

AL: *(Mocking himself)* "Oh, look at poor old Al, he's so slow and dumb and . . ."

INSIDE AL: . . . I could just scream! They pity me. If there's one thing in this world I hate the most, it's pity. I hate charity, too, except *real* charity.

AL: Why can't someone be nice to me just to be nice to another human being? Why can't people look past my body *(Al points at Inside Al)*

INSIDE AL: . . . and see my soul?

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *There are about 764,000 people in the United States with cerebral palsy.*
ACTOR 2: *In many cases, people with cerebral palsy are labeled as mentally retarded because they are not able to effectively communicate with the outside world.*
ACTOR 1: *Their true being is locked inside a body that simply won't work they way they want it to.*
ACTOR 2: *Such is the case of Alvin Theodore Willson – a 39 year old victim of cerebral palsy.*
ACTOR 1: *Inside Al by David S. Baker gives a voice to those too often silenced by the disease*
ACTOR 2: *And shows that regardless of our outward appearances . . it is our soul that makes us who we are.*
TOGETHER: *Inside Al by David S. Baker*

FOR E

JASON: When my teacher first told us about the "be nice to someone" project, I groaned. I hate this type of assignment. *(Beat)* I decided to help Al Willson for several reasons. He's a real friendly guy - always waves at us when we pass him on his way to the market. I don't think Mr. Willson has any family – never seen any anyway. Most people just ignore him, or barely accept him. I heard a bunch of kids at school once, talking about him; they called him the

"village idiot." *(Beat)* Anyway, on my way home from school, the day the assignment was given, I checked the back yard of Al's little flat. I was lucky. It hadn't been mowed for months.

(Jason exits and reenters, bringing a push mower and a rake. He puts on his hat and shade, one at a time, and takes headphones from around his neck and puts them on. He flips his collar up and grabbing the mower, he makes passes to simulate mowing. Then stops mowing and picks up rake – Uses it as an Air Guitar and dances to the music he's listening to on his headphones).

AL: *(To audience)* And I thought I moved funny!

JASON: Uh . . . hi. I did your lawn. What do you think?

AL: It looks real good.

JASON: Anything else I should do for you?

AL: No *(Al reaches into his pocket and brings out a worn dollar bill and some small change)*

JASON: *(narrates action to audience)* He tried to pay me, but I told him I wasn't supposed to take payment. *(Al reaches into his pocket again hands something to Jason and then steps back)* It was a little ceramic frog. Al made it himself – I could tell. *(Al waits patiently).* It was a nice gesture, anyway. I thanked him, took my rake and my mower, and left. *(All exit)*

(SCENE)

BETH: I decided [to] be nice to Al Willson. *(pauses then continues explaining)* That cripple. You know, that guy who wanders around all the time wearing those jumpsuits and that blue baseball hat. He has a problem, that's for sure. *(She giggles, pulls a face and imitates Al's speech)* Hello, little kiddies! . . . . Heh, heh . . . Want to pay some games? (moves over in front of an imaginary mirror and begins examining herself) Anyway, since everybody likes cookies, I figure [I] can bake some for him, take them to his house and then get my parents to sign that "be nice to someone" form.

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(SCENE – Al's front porch - (Beth enters and begins to leave some home-made cookies on the doorstep when Al comes out and surprises her

BETH: Oh . . . hi, Mr. Willson. [I] came to bring you these cookies. [I] , ah, made them for you. *(Al stands looking at them; he appears confused) (Louder)* [I] brought you these cookies. They're almond cookies. [I] thought you might like to have some.

INSIDE AL: *(Loudly and slowly)* I'm not deaf; I have cerebral palsy.

AL: Is this for your project? *(Actor 2 can do this line as AL)*

BETH: How did you know about this project?

AL: A boy named Jason mowed my back lawn. *(Actor 2 can do this line as AL)*

INSIDE AL: *(Cynically)* He beat you to the cripple.

BETH: *(under her breath)* Why , that idiotic little son of a . . . *(To Al)* Well, [I] have to go. See you around, Mr. Willson. 'Bye *(turns and leaves)*

INSIDE AL: *(follows circling around her, yelling at her. He almost seems to be dancing)* Oh, please don't. I'd really rather you didn't see me around. Tell you what. Instead of seeing me around, could you go jump out of a window?

(SCENE)

AL: I've noticed something about people: most of them don't look me in the eye. They look past me, or around, or at each other, but they never look at me.

INSIDE AL: I think they are afraid to see my body, to accept the fact that I am handicapped. They would rather think that it is all mental – that's much easier for them to accept. (Pauses) Once, I was on the porch watching the kids play. Some little boys came up to me and I asked them if they wanted to hear a story. I'm very good with stories.

AL: One of them called out. "Retard, retard!" and the rest walked around with stiff joints, making fun of me, of course. I wanted to wring their grubby, little necks – all of them! But I couldn't. I just sat there and . . . "

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INSIDE AL: Why didn't you ever get mad at them?! Quit being such a wimp and do something for a change! You let everybody walk all over you. You're a person too, why don't you show them that? Why don't you ever ACT LIKE A HUMAN! *(Imitates Al's movement and speech)* Look at me. I'm a poor, helpless cripple. I can't walk or talk or do anything.

AL: People always feel sorry for me and that make me mad but

AL/INSIDE AL: I never say anything. *(Jason enters and startles Al)*

JASON: Mr. Willson? Can I talk to you a second? The reason I came by is to apologize to you.

AL: For mowing my lawn?

JASON: No, no. For . . . well . . .for hurting your feelings. I treated you like a project . . .not a person and I'm sorry.

INSIDE AL: Don't do this. It's easier for me to hate you. Don't make me like you. *(Al can do this line)*

AL: There is no need . . .

JASON: I really feel bad about this. Please. Maybe you're used to having this happen to you, but I think that you shouldn't have to be use to it. People can be so cruel!

AL: Yeah, tell me about it. Just your coming here helps a litte.

INSIDE AL: *(to Al)* It's forgiven?

AL: *(to Inside Al)* It's forgiven.

(Scene)

BETH: I made the cookies. . .. why does it matter that [Jason and I] were nice to the same cripple? *(crosses to Al's porch) (Bluntly)* Hello, Mr. Willson. I came to find out why you didn't accept y kindness.

INSIDE AL: KINDNESS?? If that was kindness, I'd really hate to see cruelty. What I didn't accept was your pity.

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BETH: *(as if there was not response)* Did my teacher call you? What did you tell her?

AL: That you brought me cookies *(Inside AL can do this line)*

BETH: Didn't you enjoy my cookies?

INSIDE AL: Well, no. They were soggy, greasy and had little pockets of baking soda in them *(makes a face at the audience).* Frankly, they were the worst cookies I have ever tasted.

AL: Yes, but . . .

BETH: *(intimidating)* If you liked them so much, then why did you tell my teacher that my project wasn't good enough? You ruined my grade! *(Jason enters)*

JASON: *(to Beth)* What are you doing here? *(To Al)* Is she harassing you?! *(To Beth)* What's your major maladjustment anyway?

BETH: Well, this gimp told the teacher not to give me credit for my project.

JASON: Wait a minute. What exactly do you mean, "project.?" You're telling me that this man is your project?

BETH: Yeah, stupid *(laughs)* Now who has the brain problem?

JASON: Do you think Al does?

BETH: *(Mocking AL's speech)* Oh, there's nothing wrong with him. Nothing at all. . .

INSIDE AL: *(speaking to the audience, as if they are all that will listen)* You know, it's times like these that I'd really like to knock her head off.

JASON: You really think he's retarded, don't you? Oh, you poor child. You're so confused. He's got cerebral palsy, not 'stupidity syndrome." His body is slow, not his brain.

AL: Both of you – please leave. Leave me alone.

INSIDE AL: Well, get out of here! I don't' need rescuers, and I don't need accusations. I don't need any of you. I wish your stupid teacher had neer given this asinine project in the first place. You're hypocrites – all of you! One "being

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kind to me" and the other "protecting the poor, helpless retard." I wish you would all just

AL: . . . GO AWAY

(Scene)

JASON: I was trying to defend Al – to help him. Beth just kept going at his throat and I thought he needed me. I figured he couldn't handle her all by himself. Thing is, I guess he didn't want to be defended. I made him feel helpless. Handicapped *(he cringes).* I don't know. Maybe it's not the charity, but the way it's given . . . You have to drop the pity.

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